

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Energy and Utilities English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For utility operations staff, energy project managers, grid planners, field supervisors, regulatory affairs teams, renewable-energy developers, customer operations teams, and infrastructure leaders.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

asset management

Planning and managing assets through their useful lives to support organizational objectives.

baseline

A defined starting value or agreed reference used to measure change.

capacity

Available people, assets, time, space, or system throughput for a given workload.

capital plan

A plan for investment in long-lived assets or major projects.

clearance

Formal permission or confirmation that a required review has been completed; the meaning depends on the task.

condition assessment

An evaluation of an asset's current physical or operating state.

crew staging

Positioning personnel and resources to prepare for an operational response.

critical customer

A customer whose service needs receive particular operational attention under defined criteria.

curtailment

A reduction in electricity generation or use required by operating conditions or instructions.

customer impact

The effect an event or decision has on people using a product or service.

demand response

A change in electricity use in response to prices, incentives, or system needs.

emergency response

Coordinated action under established procedures to address an urgent harmful event.

energize

To supply electrical energy to equipment or a circuit under the relevant authorized procedure.

failure rate

The frequency of failures relative to a defined operating time or population.

feeder

An electrical distribution circuit carrying power to a local service area.

incentive

A benefit or consequence intended to encourage particular behavior.

interconnection

A connection between an electricity-generating or storage facility and a power system.

lifecycle cost

The estimated costs of acquiring, operating, maintaining, and retiring an asset.

lockout

An authorized process using isolation and locking measures to control hazardous energy.

measurement and verification

Methods used to assess changes in performance or savings against a defined basis.

mutual aid

Assistance provided between organizations under agreed response arrangements.

prudence

Reasonableness of a utility decision or expenditure as assessed under the relevant regulatory standard.

queue

A list of items or people waiting for processing or service.

rate case

A regulatory proceeding concerning a utility's proposed rates and supporting basis.

reliability

The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time.

restoration

Returning a disrupted service to operation.

restoration priority

The order in which service-restoration activities are addressed under defined criteria.

SAIDI

System Average Interruption Duration Index: average interruption duration per customer under a stated reporting basis.

SAIFI

System Average Interruption Frequency Index: average number of interruptions per customer under a stated reporting basis.

switching order

An authorized sequence of electrical system operations; actual work must follow the approved procedure.

tariff

A published schedule of regulated service rates and conditions; in trade, a tax on specified goods.

vegetation management

Managing trees and other vegetation near utility assets under applicable operational and environmental requirements.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Grid Reliability and Outage Response

An outage update lists an affected area but the restoration estimate is still under assessment. A draft message gives a firm time.

The affected area is identified, but restoration timing is still being assessed. I'll state what is confirmed and when customers should expect the next update rather than promise an unverified time.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Safety, Field Work, and Switching

During a language simulation, two documents use different equipment identifiers for a field task. Only authorized procedures govern the actual work.

The equipment identifiers do not match. Please have the authorized team resolve the discrepancy using the approved procedure. I will repeat the identifiers clearly to confirm that we are discussing the same equipment.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Regulatory Affairs and Rate Cases

A customer sees a proposed rate adjustment and assumes it is already in effect. The notice describes a proposal under review.

The notice describes a proposed adjustment, not a change already in effect. Let me show you the stated review process and where to find the current applicable tariff information.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Renewables Integration and Interconnection

A project team describes an interconnection application as an approved connection. Technical and administrative reviews are still open.

The application has been submitted, but the reviews are still open. I'll describe the current stage and remaining steps without implying that connection has already been authorized.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Asset Management and Maintenance

Two asset options have different purchase prices and maintenance needs. A budget slide compares only the purchase price.

The initial price is only one part of the comparison. Let's show the assumed maintenance, expected service period, and other relevant lifecycle costs so the decision reflects the full basis of the estimate.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Emergency Preparedness and Storm Response

A storm-response coordination shift has several requested resources but only some confirmed. The next coordinator needs the distinction.

These resources are confirmed; the others are still requested. I've separated their status and contact points in the handoff. Please confirm receipt and update the record when an assignment changes.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Customer Programs and Energy Efficiency

An efficiency program reports lower energy use after installation, but weather and occupancy also changed.

Energy use fell after installation, but weather and occupancy changed too. I'll describe the measurement basis and remaining uncertainty before attributing the entire reduction to the program.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Executive Reliability and Investment Updates

A reliability presentation lists SAIDI and SAIFI without explanations. Community representatives need to understand the distinction.

One measure summarizes average interruption duration and the other interruption frequency for the defined customer group. I'll explain both, state the reporting basis, and show what changed over the period.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

GHG Protocol: corporate standard

<https://ghgprotocol.org/corporate-standard>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Energy and Utilities English

Professional audience: utility operations staff, energy project managers, grid planners, field supervisors, regulatory affairs teams, renewable-energy developers, customer operations teams, and infrastructure leaders

Scope: These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Lesson 01: Grid Reliability and Outage Response

Original fictional case: An outage update lists an affected area but the restoration estimate is still under assessment. A draft message gives a firm time.

Language workshop: Give a useful status update

Communication goal: Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

Language guidance: Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): We have completed ...; ... remains open. / As of ..., the status is / The next update will cover

Vocabulary: reliability: The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time. / feeder: An electrical distribution circuit carrying power to a local service area. / restoration: Returning a disrupted service to operation. / critical customer: A customer whose service needs receive particular operational attention under defined criteria.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The affected area is identified, but restoration timing is still being assessed. I'll state what is confirmed and when customers should expect the next update rather than promise an unverified time.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level